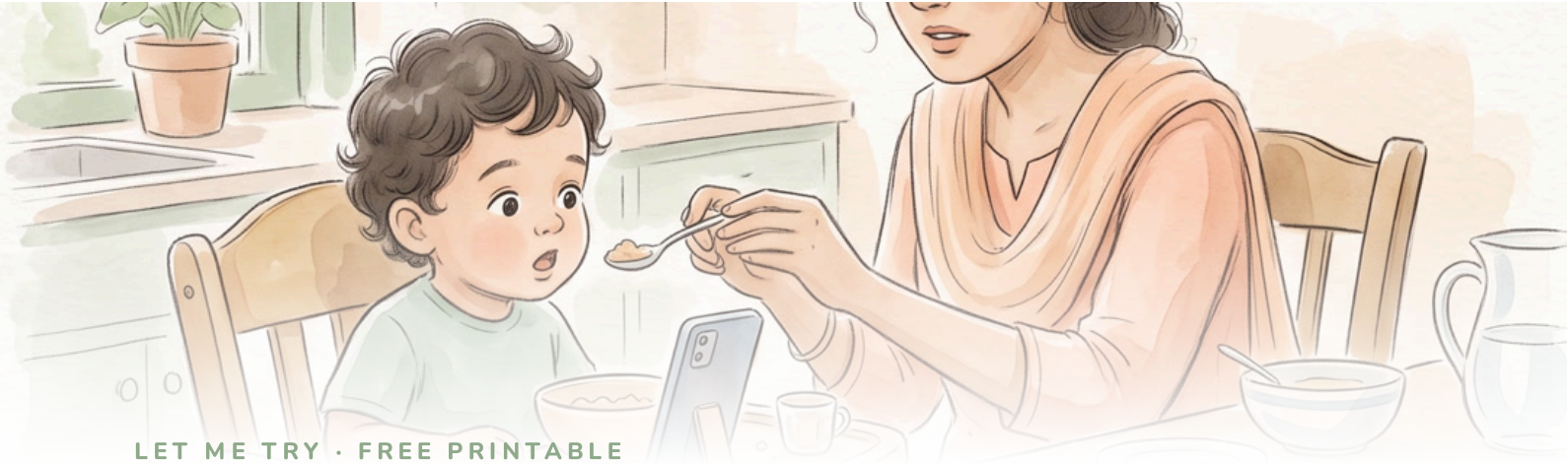


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Screen-Free Mealtimes: A 7-Day Plan

For toddlers who 'only eat with the phone' · Ages 1–4

Screens at meals usually start as a lifesaver. Moving away from them works best gradually, with a clear routine and lots of company at the table.

What the guidance says

- ○ The WHO recommends no sedentary screen time for children under 2, and no more than 1 hour a day for ages 2–4.
- ○ The American Academy of Pediatrics advises keeping mealtimes screen-free for the whole family.

The 7-day plan

- ○ Days 1–2: Pick one meal, usually breakfast, and make it screen-free. Sit and eat with them.
- ○ Days 3–4: Add a small 'job' before the meal: carrying spoons, pouring water.
- ○ Days 5–6: Make a second meal screen-free. Talk about the food's colour, smell and crunch.
- ○ Day 7: Phones go in a basket during meals, for everyone.

Things that help

- ○ Smaller portions. They can always ask for more.
- ○ Let them self-feed, with hands or a small spoon.
- ○ Meals at the same times every day, without snacks just before.
- ○ Keep meals short: 20–30 minutes, then calmly clear the plate.
- ○ Expect them to eat less for a few days. Appetites balance out over the week.

Talk instead of scroll

- ○ “What colour is your sabzi?”
- ○ “Is the roti soft or crunchy?”
- ○ “Who should we save a piece for?”

When to ask a doctor

If your child is losing weight, often gags or vomits at meals, or eats very few foods, speak to your paediatrician.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

World Health Organization (2019). Guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children under 5 years of age. · https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789241550536
AAP Council on Communications and Media (2016). Media and Young Minds. Pediatrics, 138(5).

General information, not medical advice.